THE LAWS OF SOFTWARE TEAMS

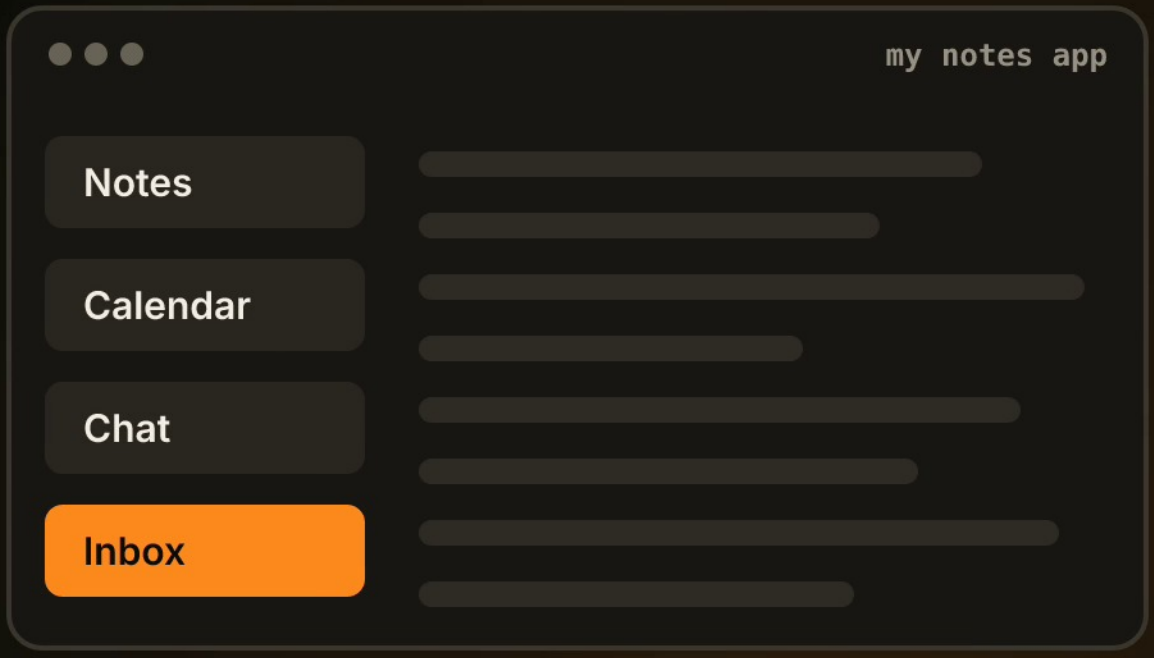
Zawinski's law

Every program attempts to expand until it can read mail

swipe →

Ivan Rykov

Every app wants to read mail



This pattern has a name

illustration

Jamie Zawinski's law

"Every program attempts to expand until it can read mail"



THE SECOND HALF

"Those programs which cannot so expand are replaced by ones which can"

He called it the Law of Software Envelopment · jwz.org, the Jargon File

A browser grows a mailbox

Netscape · Zawinski worked on Netscape Mail

1994	Navigator 1.0
v2.0	Navigator 2.0 · + mail · + news
1997	Navigator · Messenger · Collabra · Composer · Address Book · Netcaster · Conference · Calendar

From a browser to an eight-app suite

Netscape Communicator, June 1997 · v2.x bundled mail and news (Wikipedia)

Not copycats
Platforms

JAMIE ZAWINSKI · 2020

"My point was not about copycats,
it was about platformization"

text editor → IDE → OS

Apps people live in all day
feel pressure to do everything

his 2020 clarification, as quoted on Wikipedia

Still true in 2026

Notion · the notes and docs app

APR 2025
Notion Mail launches



SEP 2026
The mail app closes



INSTEAD
Email moves into AI agents

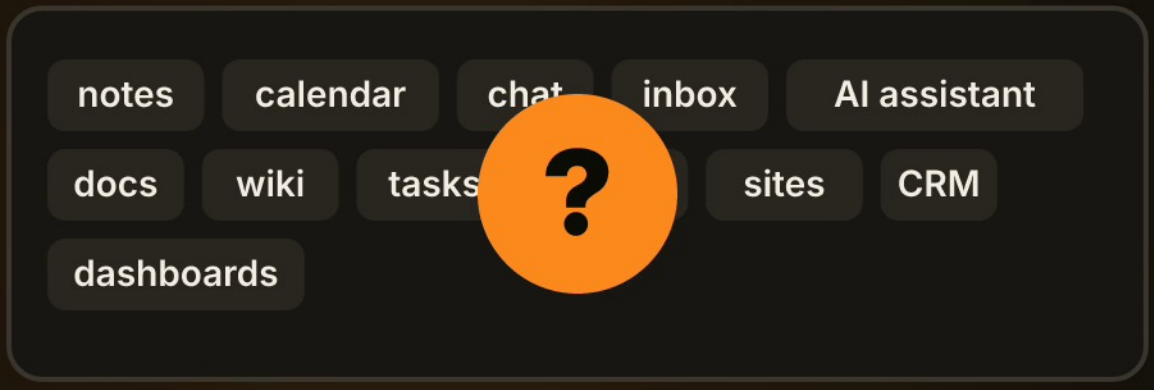


It still reads mail

TechCrunch, 15 Apr 2025 · Notion help centre · closure announced 25 Jun 2026

Every yes adopts a child

"...you're adopting a child" · Getting Real, 37signals



New users get lost in a product that does everything

feature names illustrative

Start with no

"Can we add chat?"



WHAT WE WILL NOT BUILD

- × built-in chat
- × our own mail client
- × a report builder

"Export to Excel?" ×3

Comes back again? Take a deeper look

rule from Getting Real, 37signals · examples illustrative

Every product wants to read mail



Decide on purpose if yours should

TAKEAWAY

Every product wants to read mail
Decide on purpose if yours should

Sources: Jamie Zawinski, jwz.org · The Jargon File · TechCrunch, 2025 · Getting Real, 37signals

next: Brooks' law